

Project Proposal
The Austin Academy

Amanda M. Clark

Morgridge College of Education, University of Denver

LIS 4040: Management of Information Organizations

Dr. Spencer Acadia

October 24, 2024

Introduction

Community engagement is a broad term used in public library strategic plans. We know intuitively and through peer reviewed research that community engagement is a worthwhile goal but what does it entail? It can mean more children's programming, more technological assistance, more access to resources, more outreach to diverse populations, and many other things. Broad terminology results in broad programming, which is wonderful, but resources in libraries are limited. So how can we make the formidable goal of community engagement more impactful comprehensively? By developing a program that is also broad in the types of engagement it introduces. The Austin Academy at the Austin Central Library (ACL) is a program that does just that. The Austin Academy asks not what the library can do for individuals but instead introduces individuals to a wide variety of ways they can become connected to the Austin community.

Institution Details

The ACL is a modern and spacious building serving just under 980,000 Austin residents as well as visitors from beyond the city limits. They see over 1.5 million visitors and have over 30,000 individuals attending programs annually. Between the summer of 2021 and 2022, they loaned out almost 3 million items. Their stated priority is intellectual freedom for all. Additionally, they are committed to equity, diversity, and inclusion, and acknowledge historical barriers to access. They offer a wide array of standard adult and youth services. In addition to providing expansive public library services, they also offer patrons the use of a roof-top butterfly garden with a beautiful view of Austin overlooking the paddleboarders and kayakers on the Colorado River below. They have been included in Time Magazine's review of the world's greatest places and are considered a destination library. Beyond their aesthetic appeal, ACL has also been recognized for its sustainability and innovative design. Thus, it has experienced growing demand for public meeting space and expanded programming. Information about

the services provided by ACL, as well as the unique services offered at 20 other branch locations of the Austin Public Library (APL) and the Austin History Center (AHC), is found at library.austintexas.gov.

Topical Background

Many news articles in the last couple years have addressed the loneliness epidemic and observed steady declines in social participation despite the lifting of COVID lockdowns. Some of these articles have suggested that it is unwise to treat loneliness as though it is a medical condition. Rather, doctors propose that we view loneliness as a “subjective experience of distress at one’s perceived lack of social connection” (Cummins & Zaleski, 2023). Scholars in the field of library and information science have written about how public libraries can help promote social connection, from several different angles, by offering programming and resources that assist patrons with community engagement.

Chiefly, research found that scholarly publications on community librarianship, which focuses on developing and encouraging social connections amongst community members through library services, have been on an upward trend since the year 2000 (see Appendix A) (Keshvari & CheshmehSohrabi, 2024). Furthermore, keyword searches for the term social capital, which is defined as “the strength of an individual’s social network and community, and the value derived from positive connections between people,” resulted in the largest cluster of hits as compared to other subtopics of community librarianship (see Appendix B) (GenerativeAI, 2024; Keshvari & CheshmehSohrabi, 2024). This trend analysis makes clear the value of further evaluating community engagement in the library industry.

Now that we know that social capital as an integral means of social connection is being widely discussed amongst library scholars, we must establish whether the library has any impact on the social capital of patrons. Johnson (2010) found that library patrons were more involved in their communities than a random sample of other residents within the same city (p. 153). Moreover, this study found a

strong correlation between library use and level of income, level of education, and level of “reach,” which was described as “the number of [prestigious] occupations in which participants said they knew someone in the three highest ranked positions” (p.154). Another study, measuring the effects of social infrastructure on building social capital, found that community spaces, like libraries, meaningfully encourage connections amongst various groups (Fraser et al., 2024). These studies demonstrate that patrons do use libraries as a resource for engaging with their communities. This raises a question as to how libraries can institute programs that are attractive to patrons.

There are a multitude of programs and projects libraries can undertake to spur community engagement. The Urban Libraries Council (ULC) has identified five ways in which public libraries can contribute to social connectivity. Libraries can act as:

- Civic Educator[s]: raising awareness of civics, civic engagement, and civic responsibility
- Conversation Starter[s]: identifying challenging community issues, creating forums for sharing opinions, and developing action strategies
- Community Bridge[s]: bringing diverse people, including local government officials, and organizations with different perspectives together to build stronger communities
- Visionar[ies]: leading efforts to develop a broad and inclusive community vision
- Center[s] for Democracy in Action: walking, talking, thinking, and acting as the place where democracy, civic engagement, and public discourse happen (Becker, 2012)

Despite the ULC’s effort to promote these library leadership roles, encouraging community members to participate more in civic engagement opportunities can be difficult given shrinking budgets, reduced staffing, decreased foot traffic, threats to defund libraries if they don’t comply with book bans, and other social pressures. The Institute of Museum and Library Services (IMLS) responds to this difficult role by funding grants that support innovative library programming. Hildreth (2024) writes about how the IMLS

invests in libraries to reinforce their role as “community anchors” and the importance of libraries stepping up to challenge (p. 44). The author goes into detail about how the IMLS and the Local Initiatives Support Cooperation (LISC) are partnering to share community engagement best practices with libraries. The LISC aids in stakeholder collaborations that improve the quality of life of community members through comprehensive programming that strategically addresses the need for arts, culture, education, housing, commercial entities, health initiatives, and prosperity planning (Hildreth, 2024, p. 46). Finally, the article includes information about how the American Library Association (ALA) and the Harwood Institute are also partnering to enhance the ability of libraries to serve as community engagement springboards (p. 46).

If important library and community support institutions like the ULC, IMLS, LISC, ALA, and the Harwood Institute are all talking about the importance of bringing people together and creating mechanisms for connection, then it behooves us as current and future librarians to be creative about the types of projects we propose in libraries so that many avenues of engagement can be offered comprehensively. Considering this, I propose that The Austin Academy is a worthwhile endeavor for the Austin Central Library and its partnering branches to consider.

Project Description & Rationale

The Austin Academy was inspired by a program that I participated in during my previous career called the Citizen’s Academy. In this community engagement program, the Ventura County Sheriff’s Office (VCSO) invited community members to attend a series of free presentations that would inform citizens about the responsibilities of police officers, detectives, administrators, analysts, and other departmental staff. The program organizer invited representatives from each unit of the VCSO to put together a comprehensive talk about the key components of their work. The talks included lectures,

games, puzzles, field trips, simulations, demonstrations, etc. This program serves as a perfect model for a civic engagement project that a large public library would be well suited to take on.

Rather than focusing on topics that speak only to law enforcement activities, The Austin Academy at ACL would consist of a series of free presentations to community members to comprehensively inform citizens about how to connect and engage with other Austinites. This may include, but is not limited to:

- Welcome Night: library administrators give an overview of the program and take questions
- Your Library Night: experienced librarians explain the different departments of the library and highlight special services and programs
- Your Local Government Night: representatives from each of the essential city government offices attend a mixer where they discuss the needs of the community
- Your Cultural Institutions Night: representatives from major cultural organizations like museums, performing arts centers, art galleries, and theaters attend a mixer where they discuss how their institutions improve life in Austin
- Austin History Night: librarians from the AHC organize field trips to Austin-centric historical landmarks where speakers explain how the landmark is significant to Austin's history
- Your Education Night: representatives from each of the local colleges, universities, trade schools, and technical schools attend a mixer where they discuss educational services
- Your Branch Night: program attendees visit the branch that is closest to their home where branch librarians highlight popular offerings and gather feedback on community needs/wants
- Your Health Night: representatives from local health literacy institutions (nutrition, hygiene, overdose response, chronic illness prevention and intervention, exercise, etc.) attend a mixer where they discuss health services

- Your Business Night: representatives from organizations that support small businesses (public and private grant foundations, charities, credit unions, small business development centers, minority business development centers, tax assistance programs, etc.) attend a mixer where they discuss business services
- Your Hobby Night: representatives from local hobby groups (bird watching, board gaming, trivia pubs, sports hobbyists, book clubs, cooking schools, gardening clubs, movie lovers, wine enthusiasts, fiber arts circles, music goers, etc.) attend a mixer where they discuss becoming involved in hobbyist groups
- Community Connections Night: the culminating evening is a mixer where all stakeholders that have given presentations host a table where attendees can sign up to show interest and receive more information on getting involved

The Austin Academy is an important venture because people don't always know where they belong or who they'd like to connect with to build community. This comprehensive offering would introduce multiple support systems and avenues of connectivity to participants. Austin is a city that has recently seen a technology boom attracting implants from other states and expats from other countries. Also, Austinites experienced loneliness due to pandemic lockdowns like much of the world. In addition, Austin attracts college students and young working professionals who live alone and are said to be especially prone to social comparison loneliness driven by social media use. The studies cited previously by Johnson (2010) and Fraser et al. (2024) offer hope and evidence to large libraries in cities like Austin that comprehensive programming will be impactful and bring meaning and connection to the lives of those who partake.

It is not only program attendees who can benefit though. The library, cultural establishments, educational institutions, and hobby groups may increase their patronage. Government offices and local

businesses can engage constituents and advertise freely. All stakeholders stand to benefit from increased communication and the free flow of information.

Project Goals, Objectives, & Activities

The goals, objectives, and activities that will help ensure the success of The Austin Academy are as follows:

- Goal 1: Provide Increased Opportunity for Community Engagement
 - Objective 1: Develop a series of presentations that speak to the diversity of opportunities for engagement within the Austin community
 - Activity 1: Form a project committee for the project and develop a workflow
 - Activity 2: Meet with committee members to finalize a list of the entities to reach out to for presentations
 - Activity 3: Invite speakers and gather responses
 - Activity 4: Develop a calendar for the event flow and confirm dates with critical stakeholders
 - Objective 2: Utilize stakeholder relationships to gather incentives for community member participation
 - Activity 1: Solicit stakeholders with swag incentives and gather responses
 - Activity 2: Use branded swag to promote feedback for assessment and evaluation
 - Objective 3: Use participant feedback to measure the impact of the program so future installments may be more effective
 - Activity 1: Design assessment and evaluation tools

- Activity 2: Gather and analyze data, share resulting information with library administrators and other stakeholders
- Activity 3: Develop a post-event report that includes improvement strategy

Project Assessment, Evaluation, & Deliverables

My strategy for assessment is to use both quantitative and qualitative survey questions to garner feedback from participants regarding the effect they believe the program will have in their lives. The quantitative measures will ask participants to share their level of agreement with a series of Likert scale statements following each installment of the program. Responses will be solicited electronically and offered on paper to community members who prefer that option. The statements will include:

- Statement 1: The _____ installment of The Austin Academy program will have a positive effect on my life in Austin.
- Statement 2: The _____ installment of The Austin Academy program will help me find more ways to build connections, attend events, or use services within Austin.
- Statement 3: The _____ installment of The Austin Academy taught me how to access more opportunities, events, and services in Austin by using the library and/or the library's website.

Strongly Agree, Agree, Neutral, Disagree, and Strongly Disagree will be the scale used to gather data about respondent's feelings. The qualitative measure of assessment will ask respondents to reply to a long form survey question that appeals to the ego of participants and includes an incentive for answering:

- Question 4: Please tell us about how this evening's presentation impacts you. Will you use this information to build connections in Austin? (Respondents to this question will be entered into a

drawing to receive either an HEB gift card or two tickets to attend a show at the Long Center.

Your thoughts are essential to the future of this program. We appreciate your feedback! You can answer anonymously or provide your name, email address, and/or phone number to enter the giveaway. Giveaway results are confidential.)

To evaluate the quantitative assessment data accurately, software will be used to automatically generate graphs and charts that help stakeholders interpret the data. The resulting information will be shared in a post-event report and used to develop strategies to improve future installments of the program.

Additionally, the project committee will synthesize information from the qualitative section of the survey and perform a SWOT or SCOT analysis to identify unique perspectives that may help develop a more holistic understanding of the success of the project. The committee will share the post-event report with library administrators who will examine it and consider whether it is suitable to share with stakeholders. The final draft of the report will be released to stakeholders and feedback will be noted in an addendum.

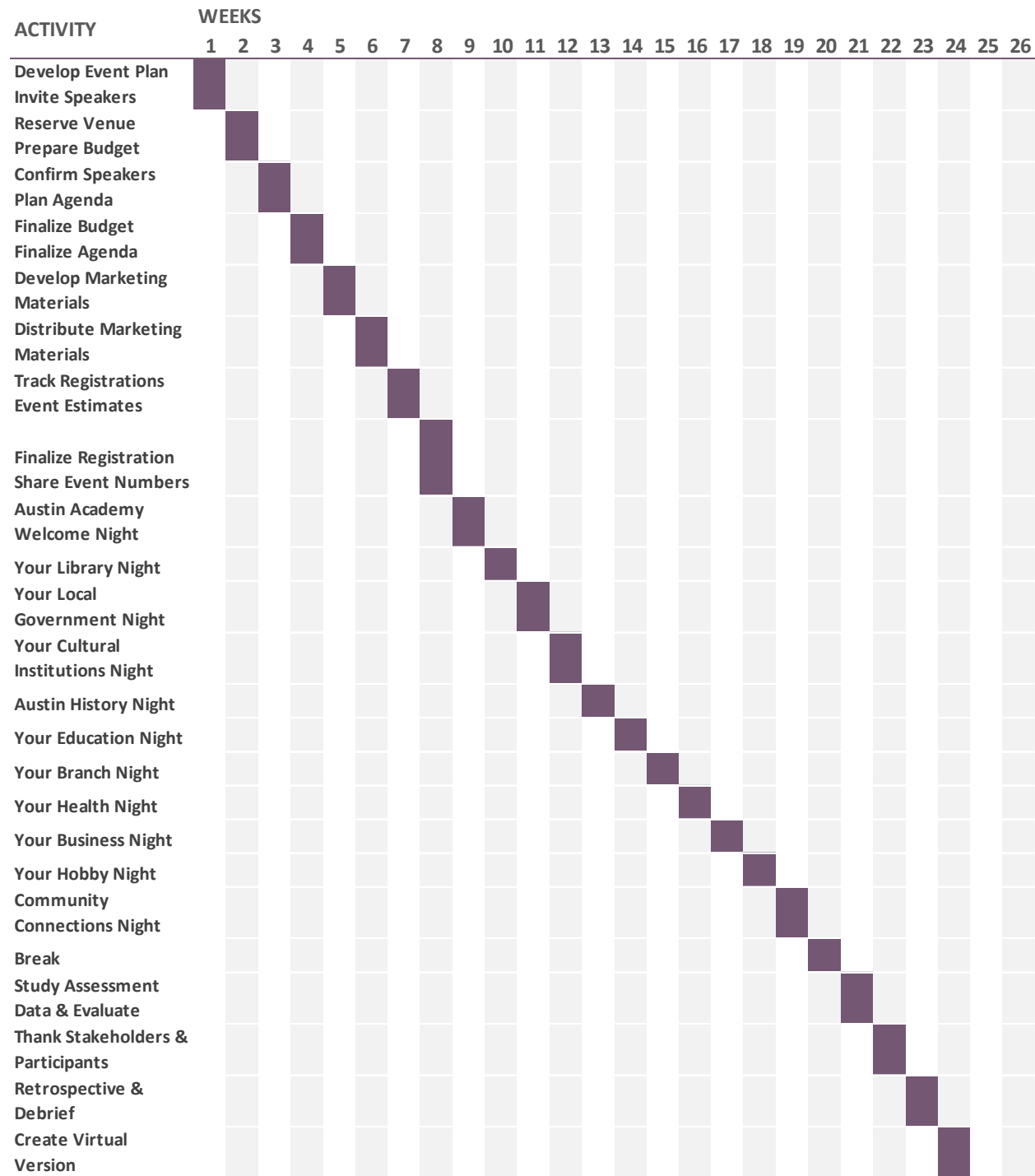
Project Resources

Expenses
Personnel
Professional Event Planner (option A)
Full-time Community Librarians (option B)
Existing Staff (overtime)
Software
Planning Software (collaboration with stakeholders, calendar of events)
Budgeting Software (library staff, overtime, event planner or hire full time community librarians)
Registration Software (manage invited speakers and track attendee RSVPs)
Assessment & Evaluation Software*
Rentals
Tables and Chairs**
Audio/Visual Equipment***
Promotional
Social Media Push
Email and Newsletter
Paper Materials (flyers, bookmarks, etc.)
Event
Catering (beverages, light finger foods, napkins)
Communications
Printing Costs for Feedback Forms
Post-Development of Virtual Austin Academy for those who could not attend
Existing Materials
ACL
Reserve Special Event Space on ACL Event Calendar
* ACL might already have assessment & evaluation software
** ACL might have tables and chairs
*** ACL might have audio/visual equipment

Project Timeline

The timeline below represents all the events after the ACL decides to move forward with this proposal.

Austin Academy



Note: Assessment surveys auto-send after each event night.

Conclusion

More comprehensive and inclusive library programming like The Austin Academy will serve to promote the ACL; the City of Austin; its businesses, institutions, and activities; and connect Austinites. A sense of belonging is essential to combat loneliness, to lift the human spirit, and to progress toward achieving common goals. The U.S. surgeon general called loneliness a public health epidemic and, with assistance from entities like the ULC, IMLS, LISC, ALA, and the Harwood Institute, libraries like the ACL can make a positive impact on the lives of folks who feel disconnected.

References

Becker, C. (2012). Engaged Libraries Leading the Way. *National Civic Review*, 101(4), 21–23.

<https://doi.org/10.1002/ncr.21091>

Cummins, E., & Zaleski, A. (2023, July 16). If Loneliness Is an Epidemic, How Do We Treat It? *New York*

Times, 6(L). [https://link-gale-](https://link-gale-com.du.idm.oclc.org/apps/doc/A757260308/SPJ.SP26?u=udenver&sid=bookmark-SPJ.SP26&xid=d369d1bb)

[com.du.idm.oclc.org/apps/doc/A757260308/SPJ.SP26?u=udenver&sid=bookmark-](https://link-gale-com.du.idm.oclc.org/apps/doc/A757260308/SPJ.SP26?u=udenver&sid=bookmark-SPJ.SP26&xid=d369d1bb)

[SPJ.SP26&xid=d369d1bb](https://link-gale-com.du.idm.oclc.org/apps/doc/A757260308/SPJ.SP26?u=udenver&sid=bookmark-SPJ.SP26&xid=d369d1bb)

Fraser, T., Awadalla, O., Sarup, H., & Aldrich, D. P. (2024). A tale of many cities: Mapping social infrastructure and social capital across the United States. *Computers, Environment and Urban*

Systems, 114, 102195. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.compenvurbsys.2024.102195>

GenerativeAI. (2024). Social Capital. *Google*.

[https://www.google.com/search?q=social+capital&rlz=1C1ONGR_enUS1085US1085&oq=social+](https://www.google.com/search?q=social+capital&rlz=1C1ONGR_enUS1085US1085&oq=social+capital&gs_lcrp=EgZjaHJvbWUyDAgAEEUyORixAxiABDIKCAEQABixAxiABDINCAIQABiDARixAxiABDIHCAMQABiABDIHCAQQABiABDIHCAUQABiABDIHCAYQABiABDINCACQLhivARjHARiABDIHCAGQABiABDINCAKQLhivARjHARiABNIBCDE4MzVqMGo3qAIAsAIA&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8)

[capital&gs_lcrp=EgZjaHJvbWUyDAgAEEUyORixAxiABDIKCAEQABixAxiABDINCAIQABiDARixAxiAB](https://www.google.com/search?q=social+capital&rlz=1C1ONGR_enUS1085US1085&oq=social+capital&gs_lcrp=EgZjaHJvbWUyDAgAEEUyORixAxiABDIKCAEQABixAxiABDINCAIQABiDARixAxiABDIHCAMQABiABDIHCAQQABiABDIHCAUQABiABDIHCAYQABiABDINCACQLhivARjHARiABDIHCAGQABiABDINCAKQLhivARjHARiABNIBCDE4MzVqMGo3qAIAsAIA&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8)

[DIHCAMQABiABDIHCAQQABiABDIHCAUQABiABDIHCAYQABiABDINCACQLhivARjHARiABDIHCAGQ](https://www.google.com/search?q=social+capital&rlz=1C1ONGR_enUS1085US1085&oq=social+capital&gs_lcrp=EgZjaHJvbWUyDAgAEEUyORixAxiABDIKCAEQABixAxiABDINCAIQABiDARixAxiABDIHCAMQABiABDIHCAQQABiABDIHCAUQABiABDIHCAYQABiABDINCACQLhivARjHARiABDIHCAGQABiABDINCAKQLhivARjHARiABNIBCDE4MzVqMGo3qAIAsAIA&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8)

[ABiABDINCAKQLhivARjHARiABNIBCDE4MzVqMGo3qAIAsAIA&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8](https://www.google.com/search?q=social+capital&rlz=1C1ONGR_enUS1085US1085&oq=social+capital&gs_lcrp=EgZjaHJvbWUyDAgAEEUyORixAxiABDIKCAEQABixAxiABDINCAIQABiDARixAxiABDIHCAMQABiABDIHCAQQABiABDIHCAUQABiABDIHCAYQABiABDINCACQLhivARjHARiABDIHCAGQABiABDINCAKQLhivARjHARiABNIBCDE4MzVqMGo3qAIAsAIA&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8)

Hildreth, S. (2012). Inspiring Libraries as Community Anchors. *National Civic Review*, 101(4), 44–47.

<https://doi.org/10.1002/ncr.21093>

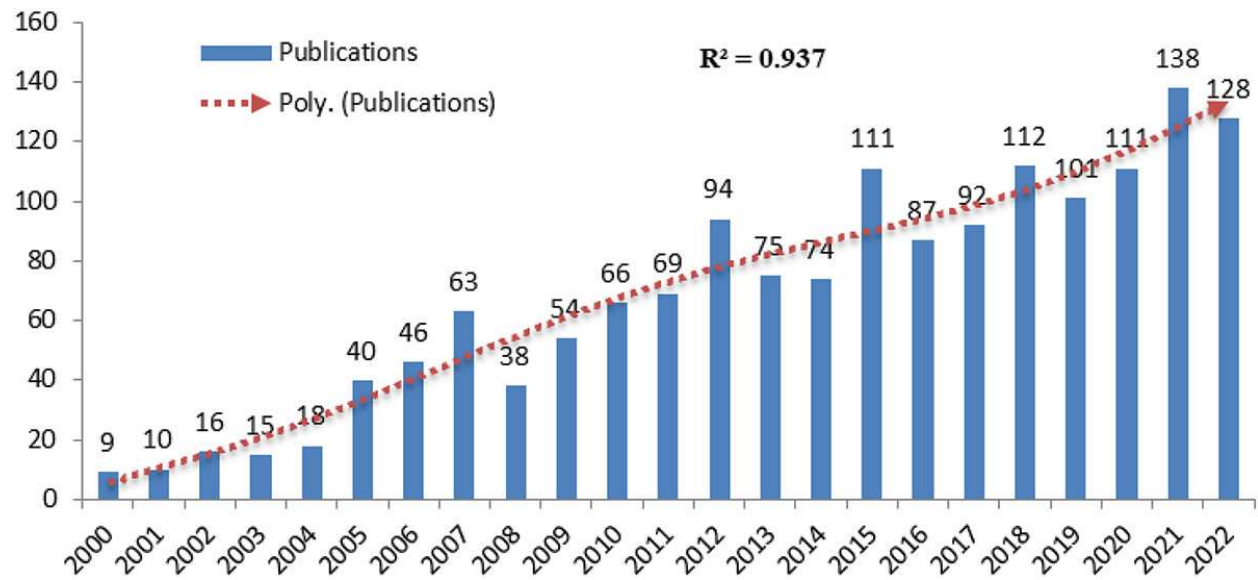
Johnson, C. A. (2010). Do public libraries contribute to social capital? *Library & Information Science*

Research, 32(2), 147–155. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.lisr.2009.12.006>

Keshvari, M., & CheshmehSohrabi, M. (2024). Visualization of Hot Topics and Global Trends in Community Librarianship (With an Emphasis on the Role of Public Libraries). *Public Library Quarterly*, 43(5), 577–602. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01616846.2024.2315363>

Appendix A

Community Librarianship Publication Trend on Web of Science, (Keshvari & CheshmehSohrabi, 2024)



Appendix B

Social Capital Dominant Subtopic in Community Librarianship Publications, (Keshvari & CheshmehSohrabi, 2024)

